

Say It Anyway

Say It Anyway

A Teen Journal for Social Anxiety & Shyness

NORTH STAR JOURNALS

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This journal is intended for self-reflection and general well-being. It is not a substitute for professional mental-health care. If you are struggling, please reach out to a trusted adult, counselor, or crisis line. In the U.S., call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). Outside the U.S., see findahelpline.com.

First edition, 2026.

Published by North Star Journals.

For everyone who has ever rehearsed a hello.

HOW TO USE THIS JOURNAL

This is your journal. Use it in whatever order helps. Skip pages. Come back to pages. Nothing here is a test.

There are five sections. Grounding tools you can use in the moment. Prompts to help you get thoughts out of your head and onto paper. Trackers to spot patterns. A toolkit of small practices. And eight weeks of short reflections.

Try one prompt when your mind is loud. Try one tracker for a week. If a page feels wrong for you today, turn to another one. Progress is not linear, and neither is this book.

There are no wrong answers here. Write in pencil, pen, whatever. Scribble. Draw. Leave pages blank. This journal will not grade you.

If your anxiety is getting in the way of your daily life, please also talk to a trusted adult or a mental-health professional. Resources are on the last page.

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SECTION ONE

Start Here

Five grounding tools you can use anywhere.

5-4-3-2-1

Look around. Name five things you can see. Four things you can touch. Three things you can hear. Two things you can smell. One thing you can taste. Go slow. Your senses pull you back into your body.

NOTES

BOX BREATHING

Breathe in for four counts. Hold for four. Breathe out for four. Hold for four. Repeat four times. Draw a square in the air with your finger as you breathe, one side per count.

NOTES

BODY SCAN

Start at the top of your head. Slowly move your attention down: forehead, jaw, shoulders, chest, belly, arms, hands, legs, feet. Notice what's tight. Let it soften if it wants to. If it doesn't, that's fine.

NOTES

COLD WATER RESET

Splash cold water on your face, or hold an ice cube for a few seconds, or run your wrists under cold water for thirty seconds. The temperature shift interrupts the anxiety loop and signals your nervous system to slow down.

NOTES

NAME IT TO TAME IT

Say out loud, or write down, exactly what you're feeling. "I feel anxious because..." Being specific about the emotion — not just 'bad' — shrinks it a little. Try to name three feelings if you can.

NOTES

SECTION TWO

Prompts

Small pages for the moments before you speak.

What social situation is on your mind right now? Describe it in detail.

What are you afraid people will think of you? What's the story you tell yourself?

What did you almost say today but didn't? What would have happened if you had?

What is a compliment you've never known how to accept? Try accepting it here.

What is one small social risk you could take this week? What's the smallest version of it?

Write about a time you felt awkward and everyone survived. What actually happened?

What do you wish people knew about you that they usually don't?

What does small talk feel like in your body? What do you wish you could say instead?

Who would you like to know better? What is one question you could ask them?

What is a friendship you'd like to build or repair? What's the first small move?

What do you assume other people are thinking about you? Are you sure?

Write about someone who made you feel seen. What did they do, exactly?

What is a group you feel out of place in? Is that group actually the wrong fit?

What is one thing you like about how you show up around other people?

What would you say if you weren't worried about how it sounded?

What is a memory of you being funny, warm, or interesting that you tend to dismiss?

Who would be lucky to have you as a friend? What would you bring to that friendship?

What are you tired of pretending to feel around other people?

What is the most exhausting kind of social situation for you? Why?

What is a text you've been meaning to send? Draft it here. Then decide.

Write about a time you set a boundary. How did it feel? What happened?

What would you do at lunch this week if you weren't worried about looking alone?

Who are you around when you feel most like yourself? What are you doing?

What is one hard thing you want to say to someone? Practice it here.

What does 'good enough' look like for a conversation? Not perfect. Just good enough.

Finish this: 'The version of me who isn't anxious around people would...'

Write yourself permission to leave early, be quiet, or say no this week.

SECTION THREE

Trackers

Notice the patterns in your social situations.

ANXIETY LEVEL THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT TRIGGERED IT	WHAT HELPED
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SLEEP TRACKER

DAY	HOURS	HOW I SLEPT	HOW I FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

MOOD CHECK-IN

DAY	MORNING	AFTERNOON	NIGHT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SOCIAL SITUATIONS LOG

DAY	WHERE / WHEN	BODY FEELING	WHAT I DID NEXT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ENERGY THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT DRAINED ME	WHAT REFILLED ME
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ONE SMALL WIN

DAY	WIN OF THE DAY	WHO SAW IT	HOW IT FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

KINDNESS TO SELF

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

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DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
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Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SECTION FOUR

Your Toolkit

Small practices you can return to on hard days.

THE 3-SECOND OPENER

Write down three low-pressure openers you could actually use this week: 'Hey.' 'How's your week going?' 'What did you think of...?' Pick one.

REHEARSE THE EXIT

Write your polite exit line. 'I've got to head out — good seeing you.' Practice having it ready so leaving feels like a plan, not a panic.

REFRAME THE MIND-READ

Write down what you assume someone is thinking about you. Then write three other explanations for what they might actually be thinking.

THE TINY RISK

Pick one social risk this week that's a 2/10, not a 9/10. Wave. Compliment.

Ask a small question. Write which one and when.

POST-MORTEM, KINDLY

After a hard social moment, write what happened. Then write what you'd tell a friend who described this exact same moment to you.

THE 'ME TOO' LIST

Write down every awkward thing you're sure only you feel. Realize most people feel these. Circle the ones a friend has also mentioned.

ASK A QUESTION

The easiest thing to say in a hard conversation is a real question. Write three questions you could ask someone this week.

BOUNDARY DRAFT

Draft a boundary you want to set. Short, kind, clear. 'I can't tonight.' 'I need to head home.' 'Please don't joke about that.' Practice it.

THE EXIT PLAN

Before a social event, write down: when you'll leave, how you'll get home, and what you'll do to recover after. Plans make it possible to go.

SMALL BRAG

Write down one thing you did socially this week that took courage — however small. Waving. Sending the text. Sitting with someone. That counts.

AFFIRMATIONS

Write down phrases that feel true (or that you want to be true). Circle the ones that help most. Come back to them.

- I am not everyone's cup of tea, and that is okay.
- Being quiet is not the same as being wrong.
- One warm sentence is enough.
- I can leave when I need to.
- I do not have to earn my place at the table.
- People are thinking about themselves, not me.
- It is okay to take a while to open up.
- I am allowed to like who I like and skip who I don't.

NOTES

SECTION FIVE

Weekly Reflections

Eight weeks of looking back and forward.

WEEK 1 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 1 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 2 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 2 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 3 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 3 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 4 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 4 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 5 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 5 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 6 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 6 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 7 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 7 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 8 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 8 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WHEN YOU NEED MORE HELP

This journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe, please talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a therapist.

If you are in crisis:

- U.S. — Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).
- U.S. — Text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line).
- U.K. — Call 116 123 (Samaritans).
- Global — findahelpline.com lists lines in your country.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

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